3.3.1 Natural and Synthetic Fibres

Fibres are long strands of polymers interwoven to form linear, string-like structures. Fibres that are obtained from plant or animal sources are called natural fibres. Examples include cotton, coconut fibre, hair, wool and silk. Fibres that are made using raw materials from petroleum are synthetic fibres. Examples include polyester, acrylic and nylon. Historically, humans used natural plant fibres and animal fur for shelter, clothing and protection from the weather. Today, a large variety of natural fibres are still grown and processed such as cotton, silk, and wool. Natural fibres can be spun into filament, thread or rope. Then they can be woven, knitted, matted or bondedand are used to make clothing, containers, insulation materialand many other products we use in our daily life. Three main sources of natural fibres are : (i) Animal (e.g.) wool and silk.

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Natural wool





Silk




Plants


Cotton


Jute


Flax

Minerals



Glass fibre

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